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Asia Economics | Asia Pacific

The Viewpoint: Is Asia's macro story all about semis?

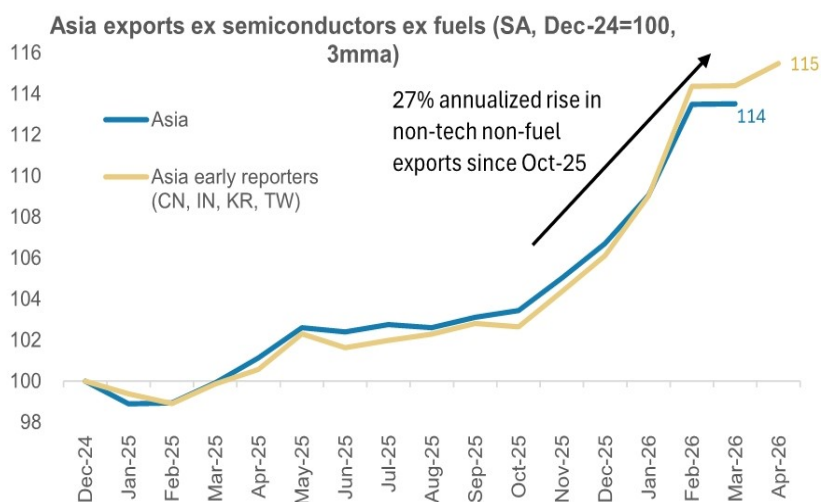
The sharp rise in Asia's non-tech exports over the past six months has gone largely unnoticed. We expect the strength in non-tech exports to be sustained, which will help broaden Asia's recovery from exports to capex and then to consumption.

Key Takeaways

- Asia's non-tech exports have risen 27% annualized over the past six months, highlighting that Asia's export recovery extends well beyond just semiconductors.
- Stronger capital and intermediate goods exports have driven this. A broad capex upturn has helped to support this stronger exports trend.
- We expect capex in both tech and non-tech sectors to stay strong, supporting Asia's exports growth.
- This recovery in both tech and non-tech exports will spill over positively to job creation, income growth, and consumer spending across Asia.
- The risk is if geopolitical tensions emerge and weigh on corporate confidence.

In this report, we highlight how the sharp rise in non-tech exports is contributing to strong overall exports growth in Asia. We explore the implications of this broader recovery in exports.

Exhibit 1: A sharp rise in Asia's non tech exports since October 2025



Source: CEIC, Haver, Morgan Stanley Research; Note: Asia includes China, India, Indonesia, Korea, Malaysia, Thailand, Taiwan, Australia, and Japan. Non-tech non-fuel exports have risen at an annualized run rate of 25% (and 27% for the early reporters – China, India, Korea, and Taiwan – which account for 60% of Asia's exports) since October 2025 when the US signed trade deals with most Asia economies.

MORGAN STANLEY ASIA LIMITED

Chetan Ahya

Chief Asia Economist

Chetan.Ahya@morganstanley.com

+852 2239-7812

MORGAN STANLEY ASIA (SINGAPORE) PTE.

Derrick Y Kam

Asia Economist

Derrick.Kam@morganstanley.com

+65 6834-8272

MORGAN STANLEY ASIA LIMITED

Jonathan Cheung

Economist

Jonathan.Cheung@morganstanley.com

+852 2848-5652

Kelly Wang

Economist

Kelly.Wang@morganstanley.com

+852 3963-0891

MORGAN STANLEY INDIA COMPANY PRIVATE LIMITED

Sudhanshu Agarwal

Economist

Sudhanshu.Agarwal@morganstanley.com

+91 22 6995-4568

For important disclosures, refer to the Disclosure Section, located at the end of this report.

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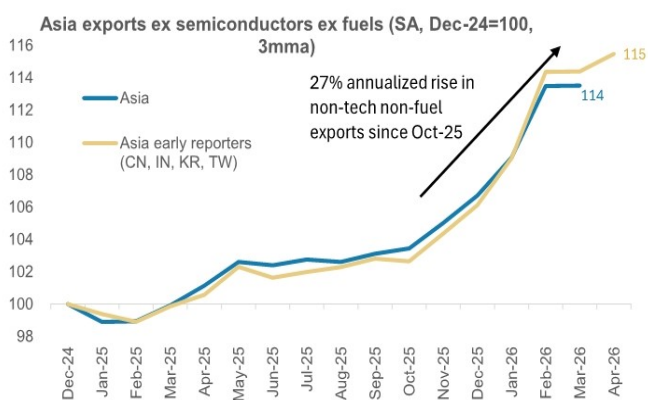
Investors' view is that Asia's macro story is all about semis: On Asia, the focus amongst investors is very much around the tech cycle and what's driving it. A parallel narrative that runs alongside this tech-driven growth is that of a K-shaped recovery – where investors perceive the exports boom to be narrow and where there would be limited spillovers to consumption growth.

Our view – don't underestimate the recovery in non-tech exports: Investors appear to be underestimating the strength in non-tech exports. In our conversations, most investors are surprised by the sharp turnaround in non-tech exports. While tech exports drove Asia's exports for the first nine months of 2025, non-tech exports have already inflected meaningfully higher from 4Q25 onwards.

From October 2025 to March 2026, non-tech exports for Asia have risen an annualized 25% in US dollar terms. Key non-tech exports include ships, networking and telecom equipment, and construction machinery. This strength has extended into April 2026. For the select early reporting Asian economies – China, India, Korea, and Taiwan (which account for about 60% of Asia's exports) – non-tech exports have risen an annualized 27% between October 2025 and April 2026.

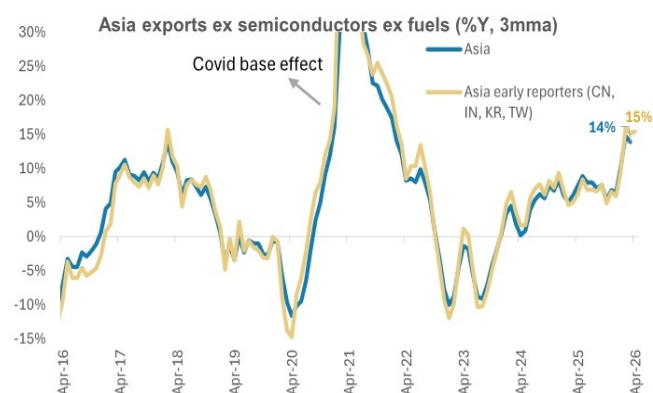
Non-tech exports growth, on a three-month YoY basis, also reached a three-and-a-half year high in April 2026. The growth rate of 14% is also comparable to the peak of 14% reached during 2017-18 – the last time a global synchronous recovery was underway. Indeed, between October 2025 and March 2026, non-tech exports contributed 8.3ppt to overall exports growth, much higher than the 3.7ppt contribution over January-September 2025. In the latter section, we look more closely at the drivers of Asia's non-tech exports recovery.

Exhibit 2: A sharp rise in Asia's non tech exports since October 2025



Source: CEIC, Haver, Morgan Stanley Research; Note: Asia includes China, India, Indonesia, Korea, Malaysia, Thailand, Taiwan, Australia and Japan. Non-tech non-fuel exports have risen by an annualized run rate of 25% (and 27% for the early reporters – China, India, Korea, and Taiwan, which account for 60% of Asia's exports) since October 2025 when the US signed trade deals with most Asia economies.

Exhibit 3: Non-tech exports for early reporters in Asia grew at 15%Y in April



Source: CEIC, Haver, Morgan Stanley Research; Note: Asia includes China, India, Indonesia, Korea, Malaysia, Thailand, Taiwan, Australia and Japan.

Non-tech exports help broaden Asia's recovery: We have been highlighting that Asia's recovery will broaden out to non-tech this year. This is particularly important because non-tech exports have much stronger spillovers into the real economy, as compared to tech exports, which tend to be more capital intensive.

We think Asia is in a virtuous cycle, where the rise in exports – both tech and non-tech – and the robust capex cycle will help to support job creation and wage growth – underpinning consumption growth. This backdrop will generate positive spillovers to Asia's growth momentum. For China, considering the starting point of excess capacity and deflationary pressures, we think that the strength in exports will first show up in improving capacity utilization, which will then reduce deflationary pressures and improve nominal GDP growth. As that unfolds, corporate revenue growth should pick up, followed by wage growth. Meanwhile, job creation should improve with a lag, as companies will first utilize the slack in their capacity before looking to start hiring.

Asia's capex and industrial super-cycle will continue to lift non-tech exports: Asia's industrial cycle is entering its strongest period since the mid-2000s, underpinned by a sustained, multi-year rise in capital expenditure rather than a cyclical rebound. The drivers are structural: AI and AI-related infrastructure, energy and energy transition, defense spending, and spillovers into broader industrial capex. This dynamic matters especially for Asia because the region is the world's largest industrial base, accounting for nearly half of global industrial value added, and sits at the center of the supply chains needed for AI hardware, semiconductors, energy-transition inputs, defense equipment, intermediate goods, and capital goods. As global capex rises and Asia's own domestic capex accelerates, the region stands to benefit twice: through stronger export demand and through a self-reinforcing domestic investment cycle that supports production, jobs, wages, consumption, and further capex.

The risk is if geopolitical tensions escalate: The key downside risk would be re-escalation of geopolitical tensions. In that scenario, oil prices could exceed US\$150/bbl and remain elevated for several months – which would trigger a global recession. Pricing could also remain elevated for other materials critical to the supply chain, including petrochemicals and fertilizers, plastics, and inputs for semis manufacturing, metal processing, battery manufacturing, etc. While this will create a dent in the near-term growth momentum, we think that the structural drivers to the capex and industrial cycle will mean that non-tech exports will stage a quick and strong rebound from the trough.

A deeper dive into Asia's exports trends

In this section, we review the trends in Asia's exports by product categories as well as by exports to various destinations, then delve into the growth drivers. While semis exports have continued to accelerate into 2Q26, non-tech exports are also exhibiting sustained, broad-based strength. The strength of the capex cycle has been key in driving the recovery in non-tech exports.

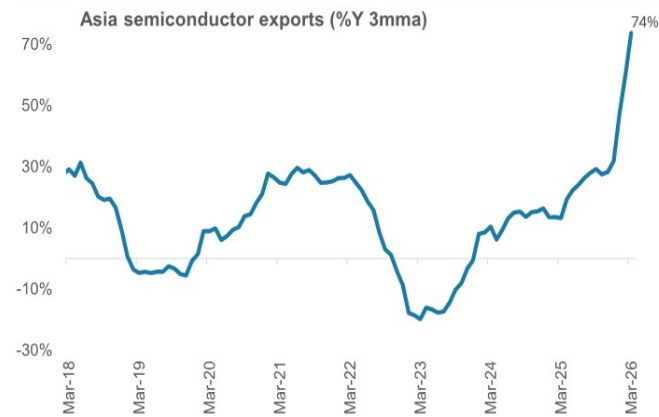
Trends in Semis Exports

Still surging... Asia's semiconductor exports grew 74%Y on a 3MMA basis in March, almost tripling in YoY pace vs. the already strong 28% in 4Q25. Semiconductor exports now account for 10% of overall regional exports, up from 7% in 2023. Korea's daily exports data for the first 10 days of May suggest that semiconductor exports momentum has continued in 2Q.

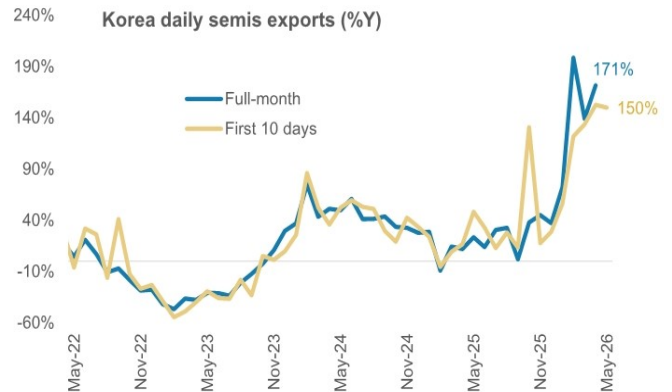
...driven by strong demand from hyperscalers: Underpinning this has been continued strong US hyperscaler capex. At an aggregate level, US real IT capex grew 18%Y in 1Q26, accelerating from 5%Y in December 2024.

Faster agentic AI adoption to drive continued surge in hardware demand: Our US Internet research team expects hyperscaler capex (including Amazon, Microsoft, Google, and Meta) to rise 78%Y in 2026, to US\$737bn, growing further to over US\$1trn in 2027 (see [Internet: How Much Capacity Will \\$2 Trillion of Hyperscaler Capex Bring By '27?](#) May 17, 2026).

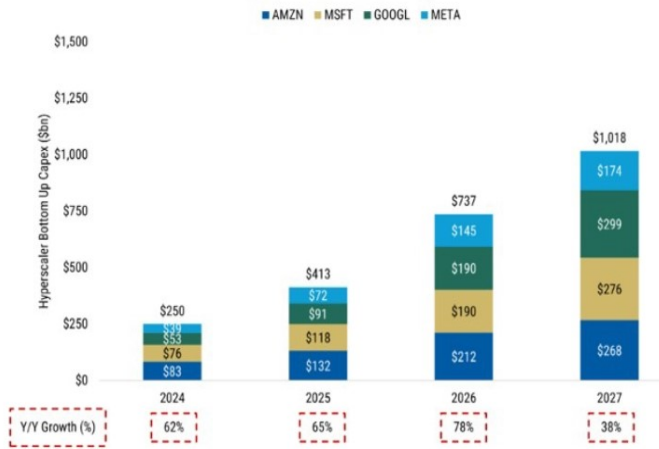
Shawn Kim, our Head of Asia and Europe Technology Research, also highlights 1Q26 as a breakout quarter for agentic AI, with many companies moving from experimental pilot programs to full-scale enterprise deployment. Shawn notes that with agentic AI scaling up faster than initially anticipated, corporate commentaries are guiding that hyperscaler data center deployments are requiring denser CPU infrastructure around GPU clusters. Against this backdrop, he expects total server CPU TAM of US\$125bn by 2030, with DRAM demand likely to grow at 1.7x 2026 DRAM supply by 2030 (for more details, please see [Global Technology: Agentic AI – The Surge Begins](#), 2, May 11, 2026).

Exhibit 4: Asia's semis exports growth – still surging

Source: Haver, Morgan Stanley Research

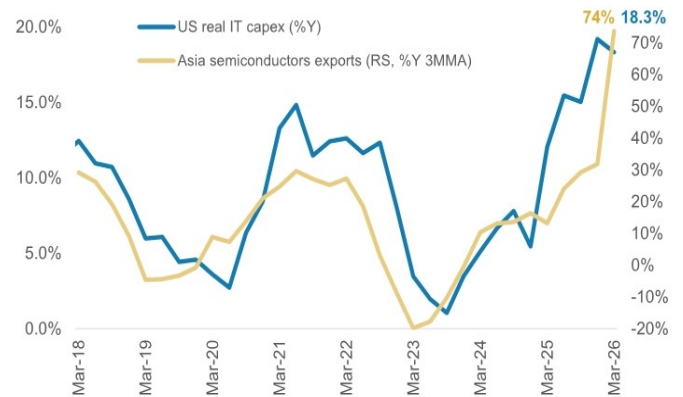
Exhibit 5: Korea's daily exports data suggest that momentum has been maintained into the first 10 days of May

Source: Haver, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 6: US hyperscaler capex to sustain strong growth through 2027

Source: Company data, Morgan Stanley Research Estimates. Note: AMZN = Total Company Capex excluding proceeds from property and equipment sales and incentives

Source: Morgan Stanley US Equity Research team

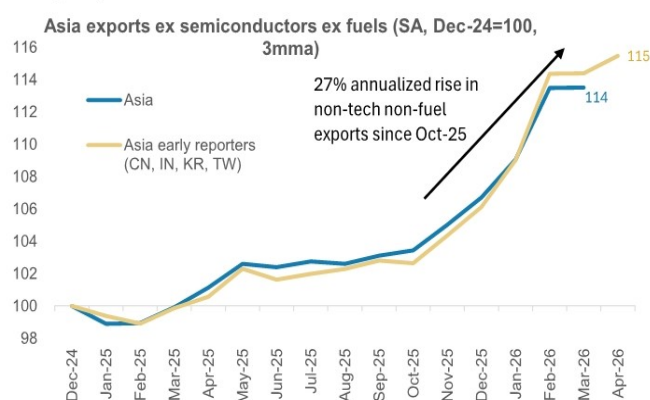
Exhibit 7: Strong US IT capex to sustain Asia's tech exports

Source: Haver, Morgan Stanley Research

Trends in non-tech, non-oil exports

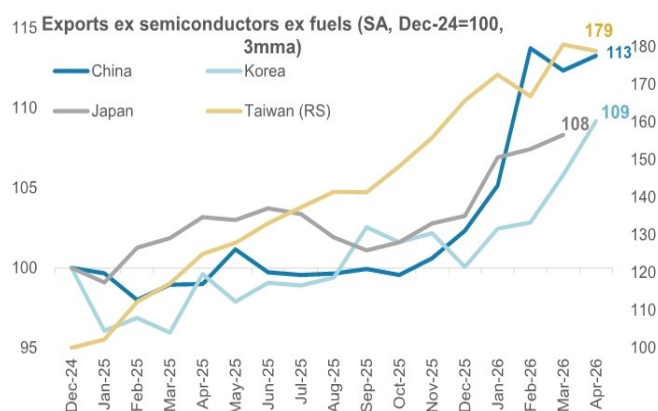
Non-tech exports are joining in the recovery: Over the past six months, there has been a sustained rising trend in non-tech exports. On an annualized basis, non-tech exports for Asia's early reporting economies (China, India, Korea and Taiwan – which collectively account for 60% of Asia's exports) have grown at 27% since October through April. On a YoY three-month trailing basis, non-tech exports growth has accelerated to 14%Y (vs. 5%Y 3MMA in October 2025). Non-tech exports growth also reached a three-and-a-half year high, with growth rates very similar to 2017-18.

Exhibit 8: On an annualized basis, non-tech exports for Asia's early reporting economies have grown at 27% since October through April



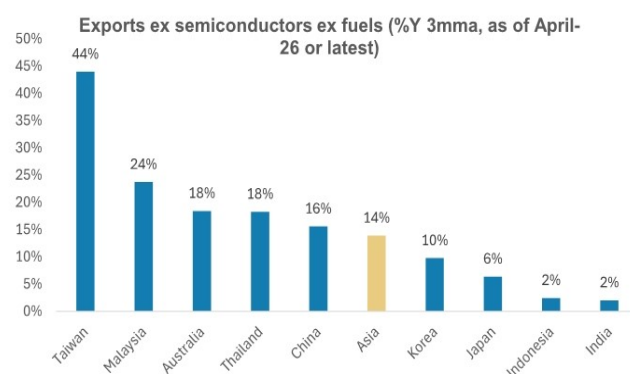
Source: CEIC, Morgan Stanley Research; Note: Asia includes China, India, Indonesia, Korea, Malaysia, Thailand, Taiwan, Australia and Japan. Non-tech non-fuel exports have risen at an annualized run rate of 25% (and 27% for early reporters) since October 2025, when the US signed trade deals with most Asian economies.

Exhibit 10: Non-tech exports strength...



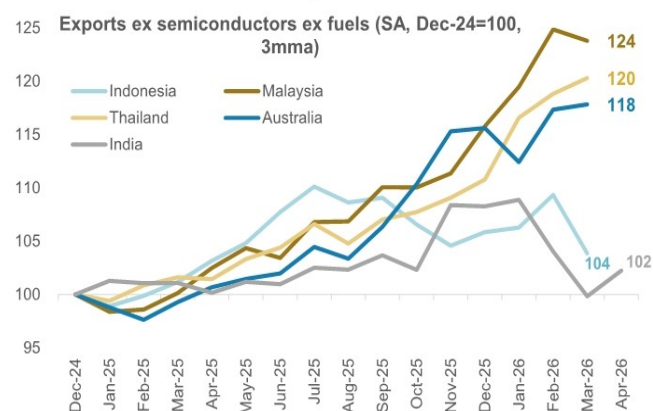
Source: CEIC, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 9: On a YoY three-month trailing basis, Asia's non-tech exports growth has accelerated to 14%Y



Source: CEIC, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 11: ...has been relatively broad-based across economies



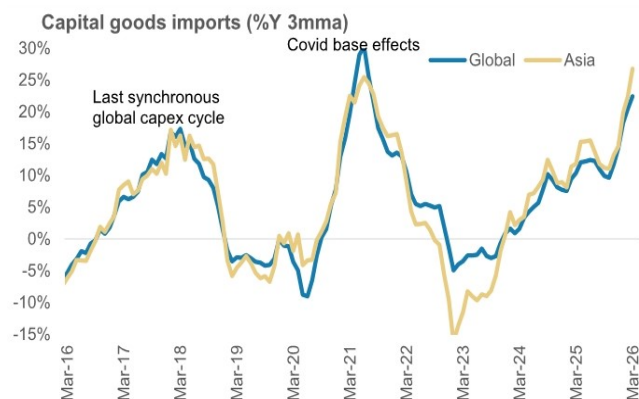
Source: CEIC, Morgan Stanley Research

Lower tariffs and stronger capex cycle are lifting non-tech exports: Two reasons explain the strength in non-tech exports.

1. Most Asian economies had started to sign trade deals with the US which led to a lowering of tariffs. Tariffs on Asia have now been lowered from 25% on average in September 2025 to 17% currently.
2. There has been broad-based strength in the US and global capex cycle. Global capital goods imports growth – the key proxy for equipment capex – is

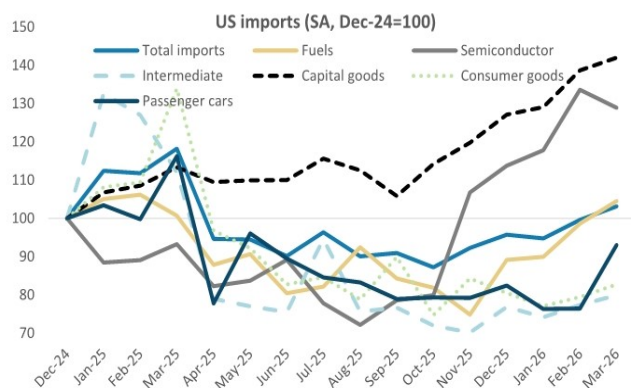
accelerating to beyond 2017-18 highs (excluding the pickup in 2021-22 driven by Covid base effects). In the US, the decline in non-IT capex has been narrowing and in 1Q26, non-IT capex growth (ex-transport equipment) turned positive. The broadening of the capex cycle is also reflected in US and Euro Area import trends. Capital goods imports (excluding semiconductors) have also led overall imports and have inflected since 4Q25.

Exhibit 12: Capital goods imports growth – the key equipment capex proxy – is accelerating to beyond 2017-18 highs (excluding the pickup in 2021-22 driven by Covid base effects)



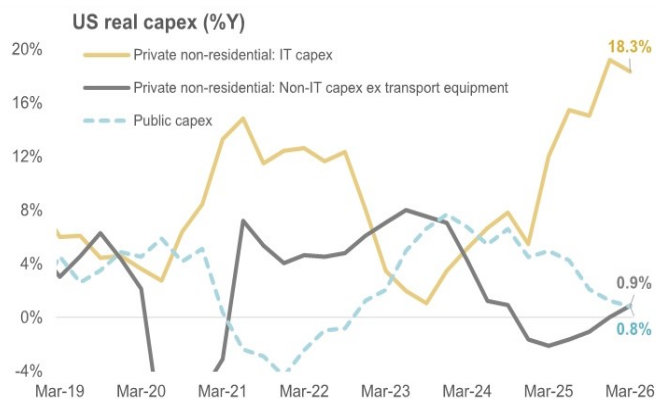
Source: Haver, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 14: The broadening of the capex cycle is also reflected in import trends in the US...



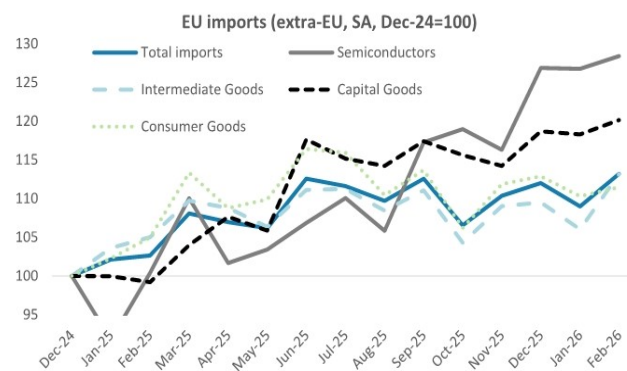
Source: Haver, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 13: US non-IT investment is improving, and our US economics team expects a gradual broadening of the investment cycle



Source: Haver, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 15: ...and the Euro Area



Source: Haver, Morgan Stanley Research

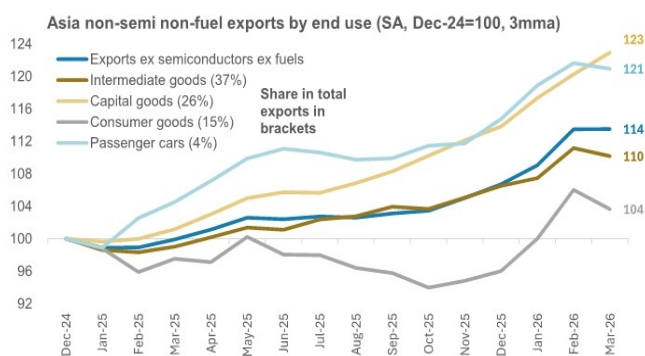
Which non-semis exports product segments are driving the rebound?

The non-semis exports recovery has been broad-based across end-use product segments, with capital goods, cars, and intermediate goods driving the first leg of the recovery, while consumer goods exports have also joined in the recovery.

Capital and intermediate goods: Capital goods exports – which account for 26% of Asia's exports – have benefited from the capex cycle strength and showed the strongest growth at 21%Y 3MMA in March 2026. While part of the strength has come from AI-related products including and power equipment/components, other segments have exhibited strong growth too. For instance, there has been momentum in capital goods exports, including industrial equipment as well as non-passenger car transport equipment. Meanwhile, intermediate goods have been the second-fastest growing segment, lifted by the exports of parts which are linked to the production of capital and consumer goods exports.

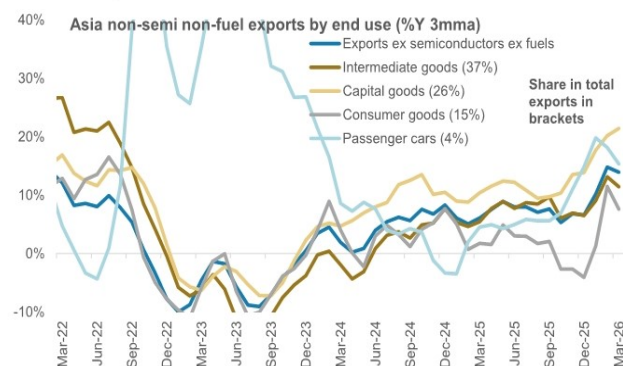
Consumer goods: Consumer goods exports troughed in October 2025 but started to rise more meaningfully from December 2025 onwards. In the early part of 2025, consumer goods lagged because of the imposition of tariffs – but as trade deals began to be signed from October onwards, they also started to recover.

Exhibit 16: The non-semis exports recovery has been broad-based across end-use product segments



Source: Haver, Morgan Stanley Research; Note: Capital goods are durable assets used by firms to produce other goods and services, such as computers, machinery and equipment, and transport equipment used in production. Intermediate goods are goods that are processed further or incorporated into final products. Intermediate goods include raw materials (e.g. crude oil, iron ore), processed materials (e.g. steel, chemicals), components and parts (e.g. electronic components, auto parts). We excluded semiconductors and fuels from intermediate goods.

Exhibit 17: Cars and intermediate goods drove the first leg of the recovery, while consumer goods exports have also joined in the recovery

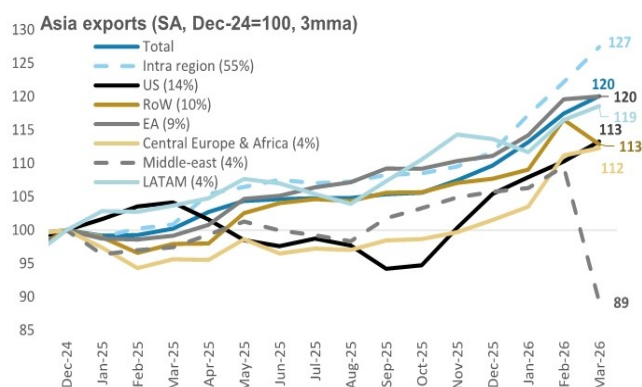


Source: Haver, Morgan Stanley Research; Note: Capital goods are durable assets used by firms to produce other goods and services, such as computers, machinery and equipment, and transport equipment used in production. Intermediate goods are goods that are processed further or incorporated into final products. Intermediate goods include raw materials (e.g. crude oil, iron ore), processed materials (e.g. steel, chemicals), components and parts (e.g. electronic components, auto parts). We excluded semiconductors and fuels from intermediate goods.

Which regions have contributed to the strength in exports?

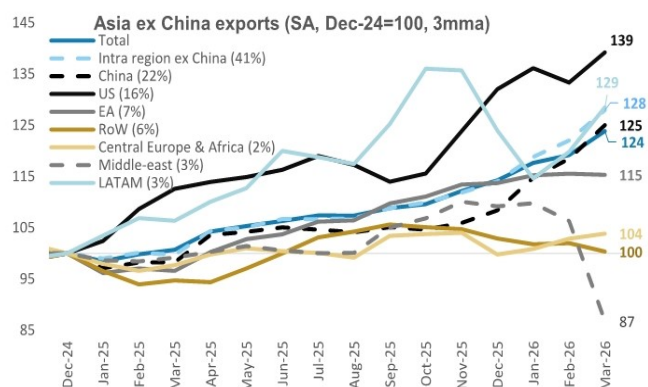
A near-synchronous rise in exports: Looking at the breakdown of Asia's exports by destinations, there has been a near-synchronous rise in exports to almost all regions, with the recent exception of exports to the Middle East, as a result of geopolitical tensions. In particular, intra-regional trade has been relatively strong, given the cross-border production network. For Asia ex China, exports to the US have been the strongest, while China's exports to US have weighed on overall Asia's aggregates, given the differential in tariff rates. To break this down further, we looked at the change in US imports by segment; again, we find that capital goods imports from the US have been outpacing overall import growth as compared to consumer goods, which in turn again reflects the tariff situation.

Exhibit 18: A near-synchronous rise in Asia's exports to almost all regions



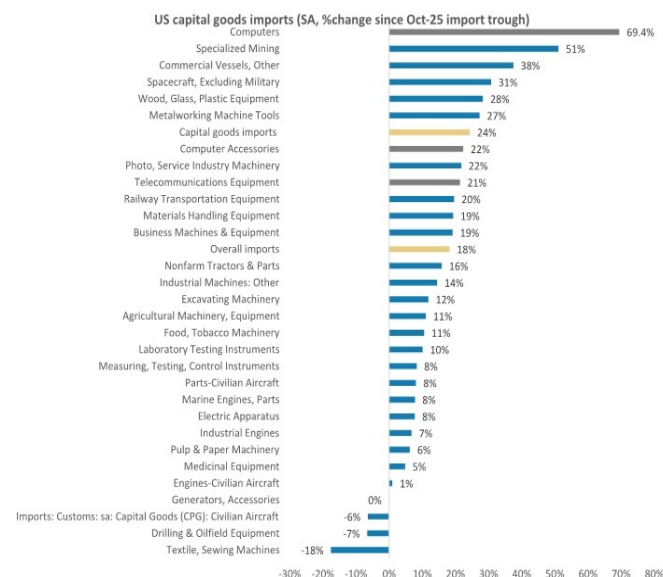
Source: Haver, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 19: For Asia ex China, exports to the US have been the strongest



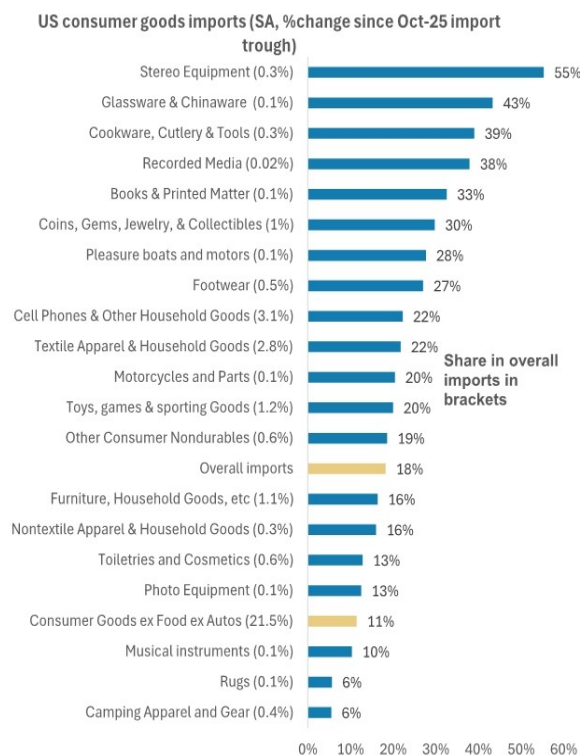
Source: Haver, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 20: US capital goods imports: broad-based pickup beyond tech-related goods



Source: Haver, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 21: US consumer goods imports: supported by discretionary items

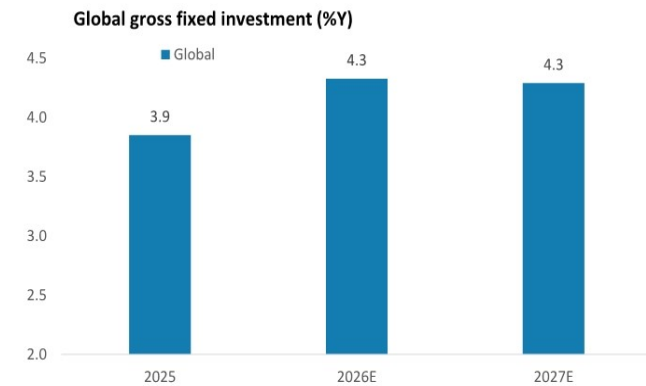


Source: Haver, Morgan Stanley Research; Note: Only top 20 consumer goods with highest growth are shown in the chart.

Outlook

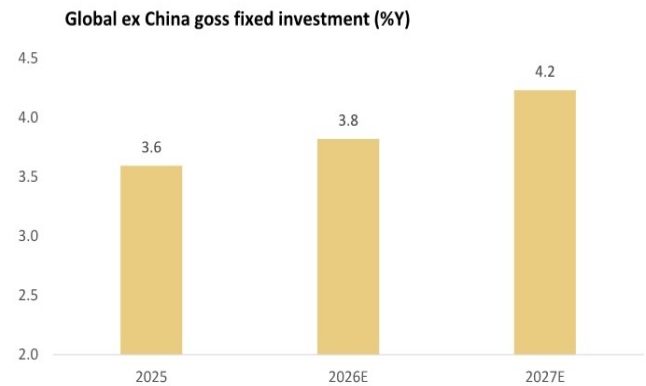
Non-tech exports to stay supported by acceleration in the global capex cycle: Our global economics team expects the global trade outlook to improve, led by an acceleration in the capex cycle. Global fixed investment (excluding China's property capex to remove the effects of the structural drag) is projected to improve from 3.9%Y in 2025 to 4.3% in 2026. This also means that global capex growth will be much stronger than overall GDP growth. In Asia, fixed investment (excluding China's property capex) will also accelerate from 4.6% in 2025 to 5.1% in 2026. This backdrop will continue to support Asia's trade.

Exhibit 22: Global capex growth (ex-China property investment) will improve from 3.9%Y in 2025 to 4.3% in 2026



Source: Morgan Stanley Research forecasts

Exhibit 23: Excluding China, we expect global capex growth to accelerate from 3.6%, to 3.8% in 2026 and 4.2% in 2027

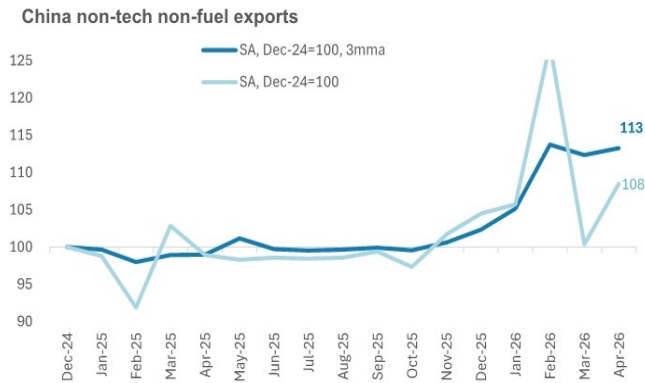


Source: Morgan Stanley Research forecasts

The growth cycle is broadening: We think Asia is in a virtuous cycle, where the rise in exports – both tech and non-tech – and the robust capex cycle will help to support job creation and wage growth – underpinning consumption growth.

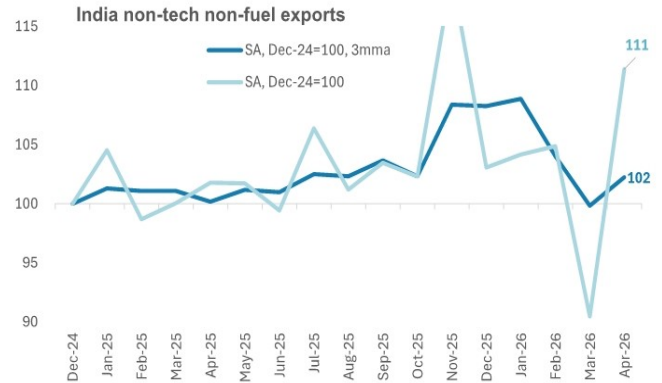
Chart Scan

Exhibit 24: China – non-tech, non-fuel exports



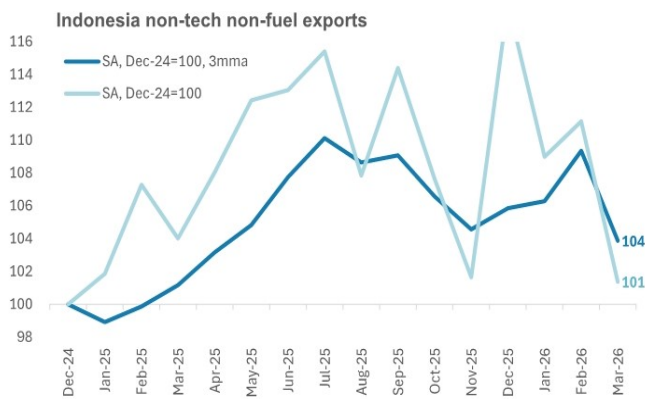
Source: CEIC, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 25: India – non-tech, non-fuel exports



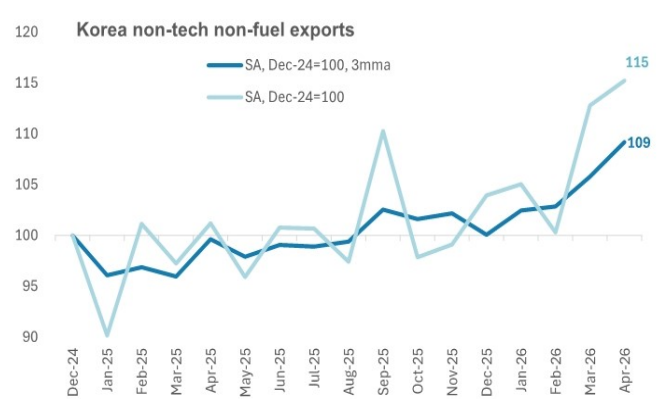
Source: CEIC, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 26: Indonesia – non-tech, non-fuel exports



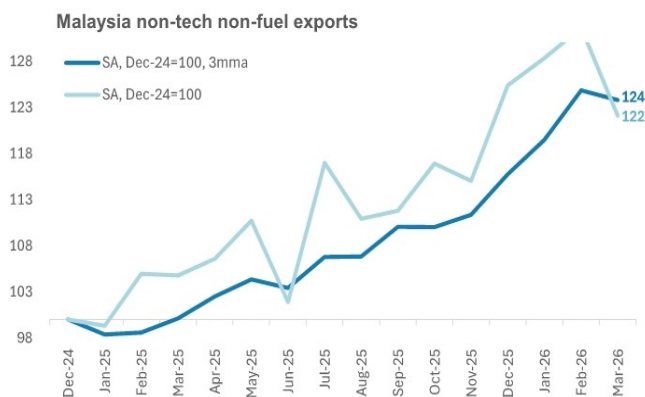
Source: CEIC, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 27: Korea – non-tech, non-fuel exports



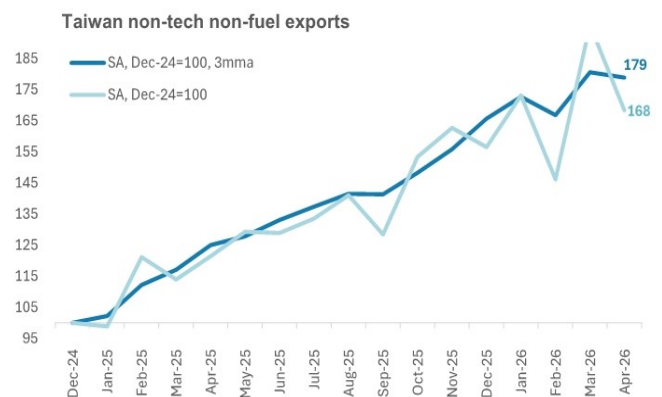
Source: CEIC, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 28: Malaysia – non-tech, non-fuel exports

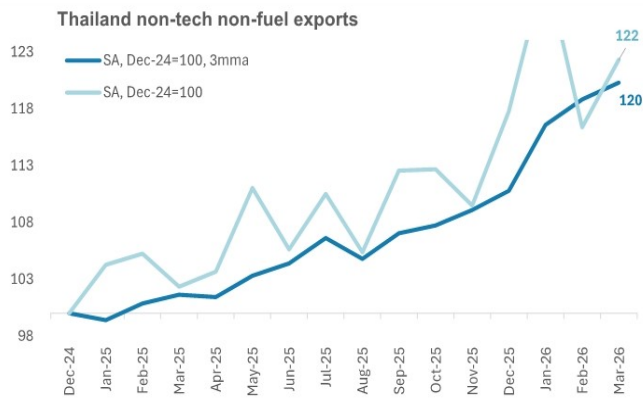


Source: CEIC, Morgan Stanley Research

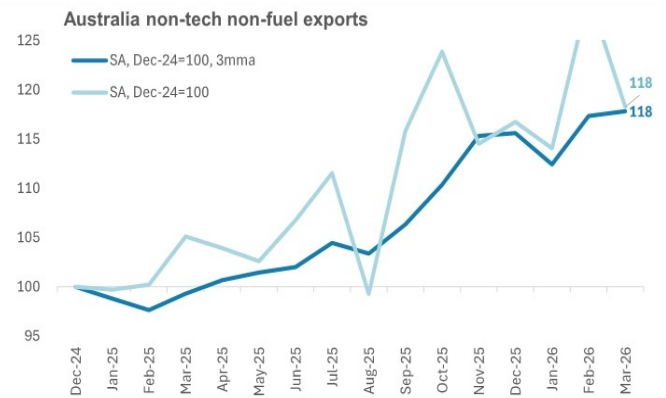
Exhibit 29: Taiwan – non-tech, non-fuel exports



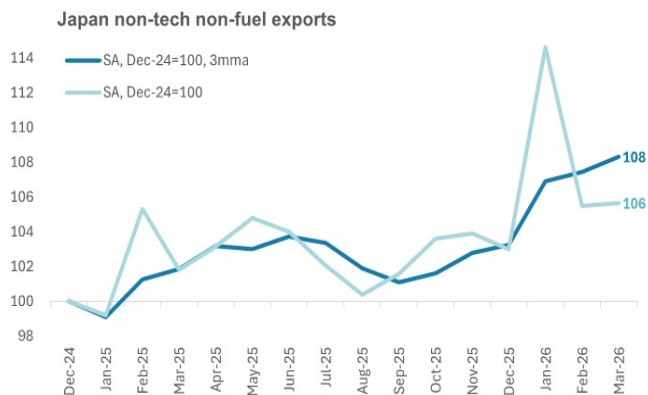
Source: CEIC, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 30: Thailand – non-tech, non-fuel exports

Source: CEIC, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 31: Australia – non-tech, non-fuel exports

Source: CEIC, Morgan Stanley Research

Exhibit 32: Japan – non-tech, non-fuel exports

Source: CEIC, Morgan Stanley Research

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